

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 52

Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1954-1957

Coverage Date: 1930-1957

Place Coverage

Community of Nyansongo, South Nyanza District, Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): Chapter 5 Sex And Marriage

A married woman never loses contact with her parents and blood relatives. They visit each other; they bring her gifts when her children are born; she borrows food from them when her granaries are running low; she attends their funerals. The brothers of a Nyansongo wife who had loudly complained that her husband was neglecting her in favor of a new concubine came to visit her husband and urged him to take good care of their sister. When a young widow was too pregnant to hoe her fields, her brothers brought a plow and oxen and did the job for her free. A woman has a special relationship with a wife purchased for her brother with the bridewealth provided by her own marriage. She may take food from this sister-in-law's granary without asking. Thus a married woman makes a new life and set of relationships for herself at her husband's home but does not give up her ties with her family of orientation.

585
Nuptials

593
Family Relationships

607
Siblings-In-Law

In contrast with his wife, who comes to be on relatively intimate terms with her parents-in-law, a Nyansongo man always maintains a most formal and deferential set of relationships with his parents-in-law. They are always strangers and must be treated as honored guests when they visit. They may not enter the house of their son-in-law. They do, however, carry on a joking relationship with his parents. In like manner, a man has an egalitarian, joking relationship with his wife's brothers and sisters; with the latter, elaborate sexual joking is carried on.

606
Parents-In-Law And
Children-In-Law

607
Siblings-In-Law

In days gone by, and nowadays in areas of Gusiiland more conservative than the one in which Nyansongo is located, the final wedding ceremony could take place any time from days to decades after the start of cohabitation. It included an additional payment of cattle, aggressive interaction between the affinal groups in the form of wrestling matches, dancing contests, and reciprocal insulting of the bride and groom, as well as the placing of anklets of iron on the bride to indicate her married status. Many of the old and middle-aged women in Nyansongo wear such ankle rings. They are viewed as

301
Ornament

585
Nuptials

602
Kin Relationships

a symbol of marital fidelity, although the same degree of fidelity is required of a wife who does not wear them. The Nyansongo wife is not allowed to have intercourse with any man but her husband, although he is free to engage in extramarital sexuality. The possibility of sexual attraction between a woman and her husband's brother residing in the same homestead is recognized in some lewd songs but is actually considered a heinous offense.

684
Sex And Marital
Offenses

837
Extramarital Sex
Relations

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)